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## Religious beliefs determine **POLITICAL IDENTITY** in India. The only way to escape it is if people exit their birth communities.

**R**emember the advertisement for a mobile phone in which a young sarpanch ends a feud in his village between two warring factions, by replacing all names with phone numbers? “*Kya idea hai, sirji,*”—no group identity, no group conflict. From irrational group affiliations to rational unique individuals in one administrative stroke. An idea that could transform India?

Snappy ad, yes. But snappy advertisements are an art form—it would be a very foolish consumer who takes them literally. When the French government banned the wearing of head-scarves (and other “conspic-

uous religious symbols”) in state-run schools, my students at Delhi University found it odd and puzzling. As did most Indians, I imagine. In the French context it was an attempt to enforce the absolute separation of state and religion, but in India, it looked very much like state interference in religious beliefs. Secularism has taken different forms in different contexts. In Indian secularism, the state treats all religions equally; in French secularism, the state maintains strict separation from religion. Of course, the latter requires the continuous regulation of what constitutes religious as opposed to non-religious practices/institutions, in order to decide whether the state should or should not be involved.